asked the earls of Lincoln, Warwick and Pembroke "not to suffer Piers Gaveston to come again into England."[8]

Defying his barons, Edward II invited Gaveston back into England ("with the dead king not yet even buried," notes the chronicler Walter of Guisborough with disapproval) and made him the Earl of Cornwall. When in 1308, Edward II traveled to France to celebrate his promised and long-delayed marriage to Isabella, daughter of Philip IV (the Fair), he left Gaveston as regent of the kingdom in his absence.[9]

He returned to find the barons fed to the teeth with his favorite. Gaveston, says the *Vita*, was a tactless regent, "a man very proud and haughty in bearing." Court gossip said that he and the king were lovers, but the resentment against Gaveston had less to do with a rumored and unproven sexual relationship and more to do with the young king's willingness to treat his personal friends with such lavish and obvious favoritism: "The great men of the land hated him," the *Vita* explains, "because he alone found favour in the king's eyes and lorded it over them like a second king."[10]

With almost one voice, the barons demanded that Edward get rid of Gaveston. The king saved some face by sending Gaveston to Ireland to act as his lieutenant there; but the united hostility of his barons unsettled him, and he began unobtrusively to prepare for civil war. "When the king saw that his barons stood against him like a wall," the *Vita* says, ". . . he tried to break up their alliance and draw the more powerful to his side . . . with gifts, promises, and blandishments." In this way, he rounded up enough support to allow for Gaveston's return, but the royal favorite was unable to fit himself back neatly into the court hierarchy. With his old importance restored, he "began to behave worse than before," calling his enemies by insulting nicknames and using his power to grant offices and privileges to his own favorites.[11]

Meanwhile, Edward II had finally gotten around to taking notice of Robert Bruce. In the fall of 1310, he marched into Scotland with an army; but Bruce and his freedom fighters evaded him, lurking in hiding, then emerging to plunder the English camps and pick off isolated reconnaissance parties before disappearing again. The unfruitful campaign dragged on for months, Bruce gaining in strength, the English losing horses, men, and confidence.[12]

Early in 1312, with the English army in winter quarters near the border and Edward himself back in England, the English barons began to plan Gaveston's murder. Their chance came in May, when the two men were briefly apart: Gaveston in Scarborough, Edward II in York. Led by the Earl of Lancaster, Gaveston's enemies surrounded the castle where the young knight had spent the night and forced him to emerge. They had already decided, says